

TWO YATRAS The Puri rath yatra; inset, ISKCON's yatra in New York

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ODISHA

KEEPING A DATE WITH THE LORD

The Puri administration upbraids ISKCON for its "flexible" global rath yatra itinerary

on Ashadh Shukla Paksha, et al. Deviating from this, they thundered, was akin to holding Diwali in March or Christmas in June. If Janmashtami, Ramnavami, Ganesh Chaturthi, and even non-Hindu festivals are observed worldwide on ordained dates, what possible excuse is there, SJTA asked, to celebrate Jagannath's birthday "on any random day of the year"?

The press note bristled with numbers: this year alone, it said, at least 40 ISKCON temples in India and 68 abroad had already violated the scriptural calendar. Worse, ISKCON had apparently promised reform in 2021 but continued with business as usual, especially overseas. Apparently, on December 2, 2024, a meeting was held at Puri in which the Gajapati Maharaja, Puri's chief administrator, urged upon the ISKCON governing body commission's chairman to ensure all ISKCON temples abide by the ritual calendar. On March 20, 2025, the SJTA hurled another piece of admonition. Assembling scholars representing both parties in Bhubaneswar for an extended pow-wow, the SJTA luminati declared ISKCON's arguments to be "completely baseless, incorrect and deserving to be rejected outright as being contrary to scriptures and tradition".

> **"Permissions are so challenging even in India, one can imagine the far greater difficulties in foreign countries.... Do we listen to Chaitanya Mahaprabhu or SJTA?"**
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> **RADHARAMAN DAS**
> *Vice-president, ISKCON Kolkata*

EDICT OF THE SAGES

The press note said "the aforesaid opinion" had been formally approved and despatched to ISKCON authorities at Mayapur, West Bengal. The implication was that it had the weight of an edict and any deviation would be tantamount to courting censure, including from Shankaracharya Nischalananda Saraswati of Puri.

ISKCON is responding with plaintive, pragmatic appeals. Radharaman Das, vice-president of ISKCON Kolkata, says they have already started abiding by SJTA's suggestions within